

week. It's okay for *you* to live on \$50 a day, but thank God *they* don't. You were almost rich once, gave it up of your own volition, and now live simply. But that doesn't mean you don't want a taste of those fast-lane perks every now and again.

WHAT DO YOU REALLY DO AT WORK?

Your to-do list will help promote an exciting, vigorous retirement. But getting retirement off the ground takes a little time. When you started your career no one gave you much responsibility. It took you a couple of years on the job before you gained any expertise. Retirement starts the same way. During the first few years you'll tend to dabble, to let your mind wander, to dream a little. Gradually you'll settle down to four or five things that turn you on. You'll start to pursue them with a passion you never thought you had in you. Your life will open in ways you never imagined.

The immediate problem, though, is to get through the transition. Your list may give you things to do, all right, but nothing really *important*. At times your entire *life* will seem about as important as last week's weather. There's a surefire way to cheer up, though. Ask yourself this key question: "What did I do at work all day that was so goddamn important?"

Ask yourself right now what you *do* at work—as opposed to what you *think* you do. If you're ready to retire you'll find that what you do doesn't amount to much. We've already seen that "I earn money" is a lousy answer. Chapter 8 ("Life on \$50 a Day") and chapter 11 ("Bare-bones Retirement") tell how to live well on the money you already have. "I earn money" can't justify working when you don't need the money.

We've also gone over the bathtub test. We may think we're making a contribution. But someone can replace us as easily as a magician replaces a silk scarf with a bunny. Most associates will forget we were ever there. Only our secretaries and therapists will know for sure.